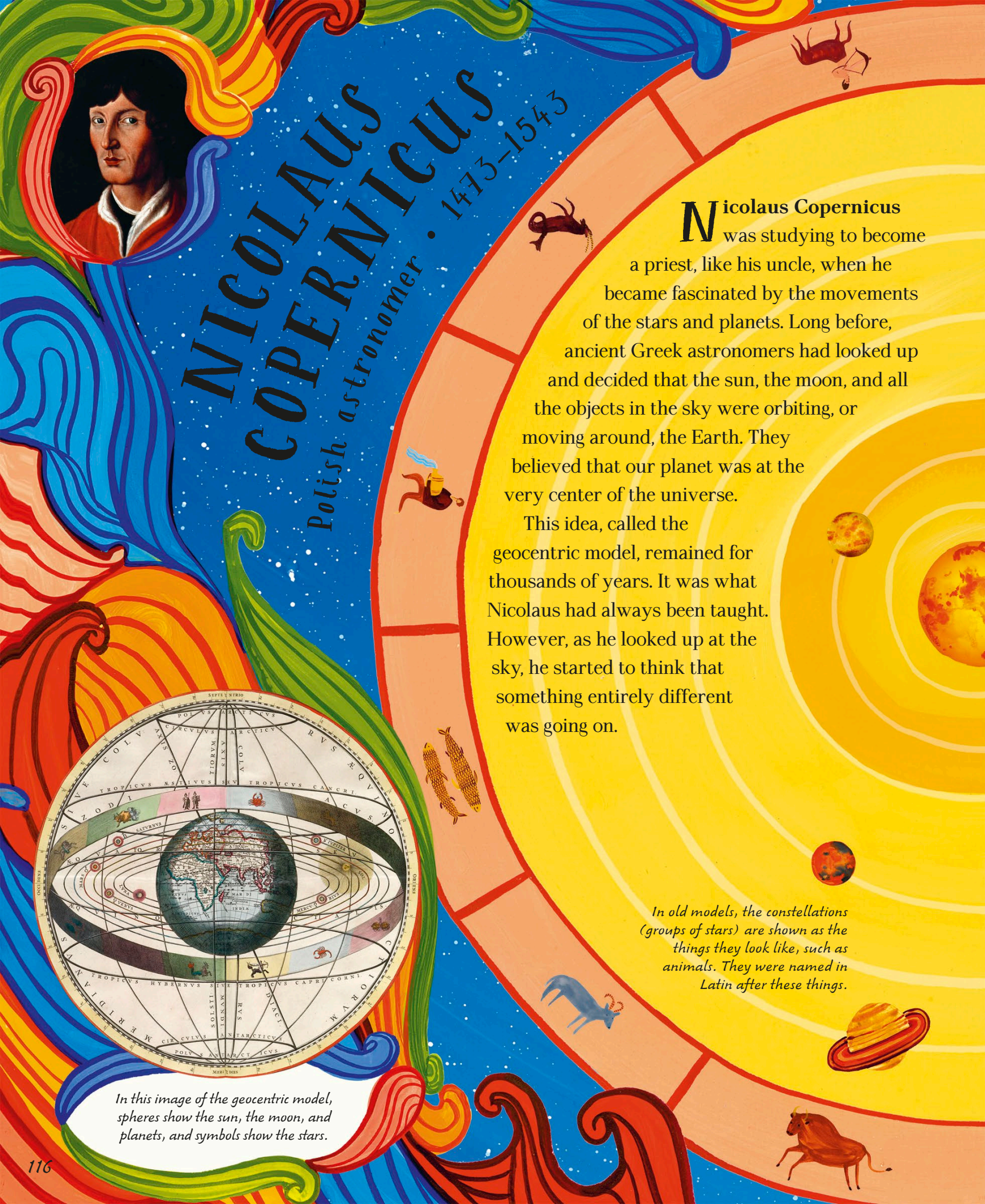




NICOLAUS COPERNICUS

Polish astronomer · 1473-1543

Nicolaus Copernicus was studying to become a priest, like his uncle, when he became fascinated by the movements of the stars and planets. Long before, ancient Greek astronomers had looked up and decided that the sun, the moon, and all the objects in the sky were orbiting, or moving around, the Earth. They believed that our planet was at the very center of the universe.

This idea, called the geocentric model, remained for thousands of years. It was what Nicolaus had always been taught. However, as he looked up at the sky, he started to think that something entirely different was going on.

In old models, the constellations (groups of stars) are shown as the things they look like, such as animals. They were named in Latin after these things.

In this image of the geocentric model, spheres show the sun, the moon, and planets, and symbols show the stars.